

Indian Innovation Is Powering Life Changing Discoveries Of The Future



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Can you tell us something about your early background in education, what you studied and so on, how you joined Zydus and how you have seen Zydus evolve over the last three decades?

I grew up in a milieu where education-particularly, being educated in the field we choose to work in is important. My grandfather was a pharmacist, and my father, of course, studied pharmacy and went on to complete his Master's in the subject. I, too, felt it was essential to follow a similar path, especially since the organisation's vision had always been to move towards research-a direction considered as early as the 1950s. I believed that having a scientific background would be invaluable.

So, I formally studied pharmaceutical sciences and later completed a PhD focused on breast cancer. That was the course my journey took.

At one point, I faced a choice-whether to concentrate on learning the business or to remain within the field of science. It was

science that truly engaged me, and that is what led me to this area. When I joined the organisation, I quickly recognised an important thing, that our core mission was centred on access and affordability-particularly, how to bring essential medicines within reach.

If you look at the history of pharmaceuticals in India, it is largely a story of success in improving access to medicines-not only within the country but globally as well. My initial focus was on how we could introduce new technologies. In the realm of small molecules, much progress had already been made, and many companies possessed that expertise. As an organisation, we took the bold step of concentrating on biologics, vaccines, and other complex, difficult-to-develop technologies. That was the first area that truly sparked our interest in terms of what we wanted to pursue. From there, it became a journey driven by discovery and innovation.

What has powered your growth through the decades?

Our growth journey has been driven primarily by two factors: our products and our commitment to innovation-across both traditional generics and complex generics. We have built a versatile skill set capable of handling nearly every dosage form, and we have developed deep capabilities in doing so.

The second critical driver has been our focus on cost and operational efficiency. It is deeply ingrained in the organisation's DNA-a constant emphasis on how we can optimise our operations and manufacture high-quality medicines at scale.

The third key pillar is resilience-particularly in ensuring an uninterrupted supply of quality products. Whether for domestic or global markets, we have become one of the benchmarks in supply chain reliability.

Can India lead global innovation in the post-generic pharma landscape?

India's strength in the global lifesciences sector has earned it the reputation of being the "pharmacy of the world." Our strong manufacturing base, coupled

with regulatory expertise and cost competitiveness, positions India well to transition toward innovation-driven growth. A key enabler is the country's vast pool of skilled scientists, chemists, and clinicians. Backed by increasing investments in R&D, Indian companies are steadily expanding their capabilities in biologics, biosimilars and new chemical entities (NCEs). Additionally, India's diverse patient population and evolving clinical trial ecosystem offer an attractive platform for global-standard trials, strengthening its position as a key player in the future of healthcare innovation.

As the industry aspires to become a global innovation hub, we will witness greater investment in advanced research. However, the path forward also demands a shift in mindset. We can no longer afford to take a cautious approach to risk and the long gestation cycles of deep science.

Indian companies must actively pursue strategic partnerships and licensing agreements with global biotech innovators and startups. Bold investments in frontier areas - such as biologics, cell and gene therapies, and AI-powered drug discovery - will be vital. Equally important is the integration of digital health solutions to enhance drug development, patient engagement, and pharmacovigilance. With greater agility, and a forward-looking approach, India has the potential to transform into a true global hub for pharmaceutical innovation.

Please tell us about the innovation led growth that Zydus has registered over the years

Our innovation journey began to accelerate since the year 2000. Developing Saroglitazar was a long and challenging process, but we remained committed. One clear takeaway from that experience is the importance of believing in your vision and staying the course.

There have been other milestones-perhaps smaller in scale, but equally significant. For instance, we launched the world's first generic version of Adalimumab, a biologic-the first biosimilar of its kind globally. More